The Keepers of the Library

- Chartitra

About the Play

The play begins where it ends. Or perhaps it only seems to.

A child falls asleep in a library, and what begins as an ordinary encounter soon opens into something stranger. From the pages of a book emerge History, Science, Art, Philosophy and Literature, each carrying the symbols of what they represent. Alongside them comes a mysterious Stranger. who seems to belong to the same world, yet remains apart from it.

As the Child follows them, the ordinary library gives way to stories from distant times and places. Stories are not merely told, but come alive on stage, with characters stepping into narrated moments and the past unfolding before the Child's eyes. The boundaries between reality, imagination and dream gradually begin to blur.

Yet the journey is circular. The Child eventually finds herself returned to the very image with which the play began: asleep over a book in the library. What follows raises a simple question: after everything she has experienced, will she choose to open the book again?

Structured as a dream-like loop and incorporating scenes within the larger scene, the play explores the worlds that can exist within a book, while leaving the precise nature of the Child's experience deliberately open to interpretation.

Approximate runtime: 20 minutes.

Some stories are read. Some are lived. And some refuse to remain between the pages.

Characters

- Librarian
- Child
- Stranger
- The Five Keepers
    - History
    - Science
    - Art
    - Philosophy
    - Literature

- Master
- Disciple
- Student 1
- Student 2
- Student 3

Narration

Across every age... humanity has never walked alone. Long before kingdoms were built... before discoveries changed the world... before stories were written... there were silent companions guiding every generation.

History remembers.

Science explores.

Art inspires.

Philosophy questions.

Literature creates.

They have witnessed civilizations rise and fall... inspired great discoveries... preserved the wisdom of the past... and shaped the dreams of the future. Today... these timeless companions step beyond the pages of a book... and into the story of one child. For sometimes... the smallest choice can become the beginning of the greatest journey.

(A quiet library. At the centre of the stage stands a table. The Child is asleep with her head resting on an open book. The Librarian enters carrying a stack of books. She places them on the table, notices the sleeping Child, and smiles.)

Librarian: Young lady... Libraries have chairs for reading... not pillows for sleeping. *(The Child wakes with a start.)*

Child: I wasn't sleeping.

Librarian: Strange. This book has been waiting on the same page for quite some time. *(The Child sits upright.)*

Child: I was... resting.

Librarian: On a book? Books have survived floods... fires... and wars. Being used as a pillow should not become another hardship.

Child: Everywhere I go... Read this... Study that... Memorise this... Write that... I can't remember the last time I read something... just because I wanted to. Can't people simply... live?

Librarian: Some spend their whole lives learning how.

Child: You're impossible.

Librarian: So I've been told. *(She gently turns a book toward the Child.)*

Librarian: One page. That's all. If, after one page, you still believe reading is a waste of time... I'll never interrupt your afternoon again.

Child: One page?

Librarian: One page.

(The Librarian walks to her table and begins reading. The Child sighs dramatically.)

Child: Fine. One page. *(She begins reading aloud.)*

Child: In every age, wisdom was guarded not by walls... but by those who refused to let it fade. One remembered. One discovered. One imagined. One questioned. One created. And always... another voice whispered.

(The Child turns the page. A calm voice interrupts before she can continue.)

Voice: Must you really waste your day reading that?

(The Child looks around. The Librarian continues reading as though she heard nothing. The Stranger enters. He is neatly dressed. Calm. Pleasant. Nothing about him suggests danger.)

Stranger: I asked... Must you really waste your day reading that?

Child: Were you talking to me?

Stranger: Unless there is another girl being forced to read.

(The Child laughs.)

Child: ...I was just thinking that.

Stranger: I know. *(The Child looks at him for a moment.)*

Child: Who are you?

Stranger: Someone who understands you. *(He slowly walks around the library.)*

Stranger: Tell me... When was the last time someone told you to play for three hours? Or laugh for two? Or simply... do nothing?

Child: Never.

Stranger: Interesting. Everyone tells children how to use their time. Very few ever ask whether that time belongs to the child in the first place.

(The Child nods enthusiastically.)

Child: Exactly!

Stranger: Outside... your friends are laughing. The sun is still up. The world is moving. And here... you've been asked to spend your afternoon with people who died centuries ago.

(The Child slowly closes the book.)

Child: I knew this was a waste of time.

Stranger: Come. I'll show you something far more interesting. *(He extends his hand. The Child looks at the open book for a moment... then quietly takes the Stranger's hand. The Stranger smiles. Together, they begin walking toward the exit. Just as they are about to leave...)*

Voice: Wait.

(Both stop immediately. Neither of them moves. The Stranger slowly closes his eyes for a brief moment. Recognition. History steps into view. He looks only at the Stranger.)

History: Leaving already? You never stay long enough to witness the ending.

(The Stranger smiles like greeting an old acquaintance.)

Stranger: And you never learned to stop looking behind you.

History: Someone must.

(The Child looks from one to the other, utterly confused.)

Child: Who... are you?

History: Someone who has watched far too many children make the same choice.

(Another voice answers. Science steps into the light. Simple clothing. He studies the Stranger as though observing an experiment rather than an enemy.)

Science: And someone who has spent just as long trying to help them choose differently. Perhaps... we should begin there.

History: So... it begins again.

(Art, Philosophy and Literature enters)

Child: Can somebody please explain what's happening? Who are all of you?

(No one answers immediately. Every Keeper is looking at the Stranger.)

Stranger: Must we do this... again?

History: As long as you return... so shall we.

Stranger: You still believe you'll win.

Science: Winning has never been our purpose.

Stranger: No. Only delaying me.

Child: Excuse me! I'm still here!

(For the first time, everyone turns toward the Child.)

Art: Of course you are. Without you... none of us would be.

Child: That answered absolutely nothing.

(A few laughs.)

Stranger: You see? Nothing has changed. They've always spoken like riddles.

(He turns toward the Child.)

Stranger: Would you like me to explain?

(The Keepers remain silent. They allow him.)

Child: Please.

Stranger: They think I lead people away. I don't. I simply offer another path. Some choose me. Some don't.

Child: That's it?

Stranger: That's all it has ever been.

Philosophy: A choice... without understanding... is not truly a choice.

Stranger: And there it is. You believe every choice must first be understood.

Literature: We don't ask anyone to choose us. We simply ask them... to know what they are choosing.

Child: If you're all telling the truth... what exactly are you asking me to choose?

Stranger: Nothing extraordinary. Come outside. Leave the book. Spend your day living instead of reading about life.

Child: That... actually sounds reasonable.

Stranger: Most reasonable things do.

Science: May I ask you something?

Child: ...

Science: Why did you come to the library today?

Child: My mother thought it would be good for me.

Science: And if she hadn't?

Child: I probably wouldn't have come.

Science: Perhaps... your dislike isn't for books. Perhaps... you simply haven't found the right one.

(The Child thinks.)

Child: ... Maybe.

(The Stranger smiles knowingly.)

Stranger: There you are. Always asking questions until people doubt themselves.

Science: Questions are kinder than assumptions.

(The Stranger turns back toward the Child.)

Stranger: Very well. Then allow me one. How many books have you read?

Child: I don't know.

Stranger: How many do you remember?

(The Child hesitates.)

Child: Not many.

Stranger: Exactly. Years spent reading. Most forgotten. Wouldn't your time have been better spent... living?

(Silence. The Child slowly nods.)

Child: I suppose...

(The Stranger takes one slow step closer.)

Stranger: Tell me. Can you recite every lesson your teachers taught? Every chapter? Every poem? Every date?

Child: No.

Stranger: Then why chase knowledge that slips away the moment you close the book?

(Silence. For the first time, the Keepers have no immediate reply.)

Child: ... That's actually a good question.

(The Stranger smiles. He knows he has won the first exchange. Literature, who has remained silent until now, quietly closes the book in his hands. He walks to the Child.)

Literature: May I tell you a story?

Stranger: Naturally. When reason struggles... stories arrive.

Literature: Perhaps.

(The other Keepers and the Stranger step aside as a MASTER and a DISCIPLE silently enter. As Literature narrates, the corresponding actions unfold before the Child.)

Literature: A young disciple once complained to his master. "I keep reading... but I forget everything. The books stay. The words disappear. What is the use?" The master handed him a dirty sieve. "Bring me water." The disciple laughed. "It cannot hold water." "Try." Again. And again. And again. Each time... the water escaped. At last, the disciple returned. "I failed." The master smiled. "Look again." The sieve was still empty. But it was no longer dirty.

Literature: Not everything we receive... is meant to remain. Sometimes... it is enough that it changes us.

(The MASTER and DISCIPLE quietly exit as the Keepers and the Stranger return to their places.)

(The Child looks down. She doesn't answer immediately.)

Stranger: A beautiful story. But you've answered his question... not his heart. Can curiosity be taught... or only discovered?

(Literature remains silent.)

Art: No. It cannot.

(The Stranger smiles, thinking he has won.)

Art: But it can be awakened.

Stranger: And how exactly do you awaken it?

Art: Every painting... every poem... every story... began because someone dared to ask a question no one else had asked.

Stranger: Perhaps. But none of them mattered until someone lived them. A song unheard... is only ink. A painting unseen... is only colour. A story unread... is only paper. Life gives them meaning.

(Silence. The Child slowly looks from one side to the other.)

Child: You're both making sense. How am I supposed to know who's right?

Stranger: Simple. Ask yourself one question. If you had one free afternoon, would you rather spend it reading about life... or living it?

Child: ...Living it.

Stranger: Exactly. Life first. Everything else later.

(History slowly steps forward.)

History: Tell me. Do you know the name... Nalanda?

Child: The university?

(The other Keepers and the Stranger step aside as STUDENTS silently enter. As History speaks, the corresponding events unfold before the Child.)

History: Once... one of the greatest centres of learning the world had ever known. Thousands upon thousands of minds... met there. Students travelled across kingdoms... simply to learn. Then... fire. The flames burned for months. The silence... has lasted centuries. Tell me. What was lost?

(The STUDENTS quietly exit with the stack of books as the Keepers and the Stranger return to their places.)

Child: Books.

History: Only books?

Child: ...Ideas?

History: Questions. Dreams. Discoveries. Names. Lives. Things humanity has searched for ever since... because no one remembered them.

Stranger: Or perhaps... nothing important was lost. If those ideas truly mattered... wouldn't someone simply have written them again?

Child: Could they?

Science: Some of it. But not all. Every book destroyed... is a conversation that must begin again. How many years... were spent rediscovering... what had already been known?

Stranger: And yet... humanity survived.

History: Survived. Yes. But survival... is not the same as progress.

(The Stranger slowly walks across the library.)

Stranger: You speak of old libraries. Old kingdoms. Old tragedies. Look around. People carry more knowledge in their pockets than kings once possessed. Why spend years remembering... when answers arrive in seconds?

Child: That's true. If I forget something... I just search for it.

Stranger: Exactly. Why fill your mind... when the world remembers for you?

(Silence. Philosophy steps forward for the first time.)

Philosophy: May I ask... who is remembering? The machine? Or you?

Stranger: Does it matter?

Philosophy: More than you think. There is a difference... between finding an answer... and understanding it. Suppose I hand you... the answer to every examination... without teaching you anything. Would you become wiser?

Child: No.

Philosophy: Why not?

Child: Because... I wouldn't know why the answer is right.

(Philosophy smiles.)

Philosophy: Exactly.

Stranger: Very well. Then let me ask something different. Why spend three hours writing an essay... when a machine can write it in thirty seconds?

Child: ...I don't know.

Stranger: Would the marks be different? Would the paper care? Would the examiner know?

(Silence.)

Stranger: Tell me honestly. How many people... would still choose the harder path?

(No one answers. The Child slowly walks away from both sides. She stands alone.)

Child: I... don't know anymore. You all sound right.

Stranger: Because there is no villain here. Only choices.

Child: Then why are all of you fighting?

(Silence.)

History: We are not fighting over books.

Science: Or libraries.

Literature: We are fighting... for what becomes of those who choose.

Child: No!

(Everyone falls silent.)

Child: I've been standing here listening to all of you. One moment you're arguing... the next you're telling me there is no fight. Which is it? Are you against each other... or aren't you?

(A long silence. For the first time, History looks towards the Stranger. The Stranger meets his gaze.)

History: We have disagreed... for longer than kingdoms have stood.

Stranger: And yet... here we still are.

Philosophy: Not every disagreement is a war.

Science: A question challenges an answer. An answer gives birth to another question. Neither exists for long... without the other.

Art: Light gives meaning to shadow. Shadow gives meaning to light.

Stranger: They mistake me for the problem. I never was. I have always been... the alternative.

History: Nor are we always right.

Stranger: A child who never leaves his books... misses the world.

Literature: A child who never opens one... may never truly understand it.

(The Child slowly looks from one side to the other.)

Child: Then... none of you are trying to defeat the other.

History: No.

Science: We have always existed together.

Stranger: The choice was never between us.

Philosophy: Only in how you learn to balance us.

(The Child thinks for a long moment.)

Child: I think...

I've been asking the wrong question. It was never..."Who is right?" It was... "When should I listen to each of you?"

(No one answers. For the first time, all six simply smile. The Librarian exits, reading a book)

Child: I still don't understand. Who... are you?

History: Tell me... when you first saw me... who did you think I was?

Child: A king. Maybe... Ashoka.

Science: And me?

Child: Einstein.

Art: Another child... might see me as Leonardo. Or Raja Ravi Varma.

Science: Another... might have seen Aryabhata.

Literature: Someone else... may not recognise any of us at all.

Child: Then... who are you really?

History: You gave us faces... so that you could understand us.

Science: Children understand people... before they understand ideas.

Philosophy: So your mind... made us people.

Child: You aren't... really... people?

(None of them answers directly.)

(The Stranger laughs quietly.)

Stranger: They've always enjoyed mysteries.

Child: And... what about you? Who are you?

Stranger: I've been called many things. Convenience. Comfort. Distraction. Escape. Progress. Freedom. Names change. The invitation never does.

Child: If... I choose to read... will you disappear?

Stranger: No.

Child: If I stop reading?

Stranger: They won't disappear either. Every day… someone chooses when to open a book... and when to close it. Again. And again. And again.

(The Child slowly walks to the book. She sits. She opens it. The five Keepers and the Stranger each take a quiet step back.)

Child: "In every age, wisdom was guarded not by walls... but by those who refused to let it fade."

Child: "One remembered."

(History exits.)

Child: "One discovered."

(Science exits.)

Child: "One imagined."

(Art exits.)

Child: "One questioned."

(Philosophy exits.)

Child: "One created."

(Literature exits.)

Child: "And always..."

(She stops. A silence. She slowly looks up. The Keepers and the Stranger are gone. She looks around the library. No one is there. Suddenly, she drops forward onto the table, her head resting on the open book exactly as in the opening scene. The Librarian enters, carrying a stack of books. She places the stack of books beside the Child.)

Librarian: Young lady... You're in a library. At least read something. *(The Child wakes with a start.)*

Child: You... Weren't you here?

Librarian: Here? You've been asleep.

(The Child sits upright. The Librarian gently turns one of the books toward her.)

Librarian: Here. Read.

(The Librarian exits. As the Child looks down at the book, the Stranger silently appears behind her.)

Stranger (from behind the Child): Must you really waste your day reading all that?

(The Child grips the back of her chair and begins to rise. A brief pause. She looks at the book... then slowly sits back down. She opens the book. Instantly, the five Keepers and the Stranger drop into a synchronized crouch and disappear into the darkness, leaving only the Child at the centre of the stage, reading.)

(Blackout.)

Production Notes

1. Structure and Interpretation

The play employs two principal structural devices: a **dream-like loop** and **scenes within the larger scene**.

The overall narrative follows a circular structure. The Child begins asleep at the Central Table and, after the events of the play, returns to the same physical position. The repetition is deliberate and contributes to the dream-like ambiguity of the narrative.

The events experienced by the Child may be understood as taking place within her imagination or as a dream. The play deliberately avoids establishing a rigid boundary between reality and imagination.

The Librarian remains grounded in the ordinary world of the library and does not acknowledge or react to the extraordinary events experienced by the Child. Within the larger narrative, certain stories are not merely narrated. They are **narrated and simultaneously enacted on stage**.

In the **Sieve Story**, Literature narrates the episode while the Master and Disciple physically enact it in the central performance space. In the **Nalanda Scene**, History narrates the episode while the students physically enact the events being described. These therefore function as **scenes within the larger scene**, allowing the audience to experience the stories simultaneously through narration and physical action. The narrating Keeper remains outside the central action while the characters within the narrated story occupy the open central space.

2. Stage Layout

The play uses a **fixed stage arrangement**. No changes to the physical set are required during the performance. The different scenes are created through the movement and positioning of the actors.

All stage directions in these Production Notes are given from the audience's point of view.

The stage consists of the following principal elements:

- **Central Table:** Positioned slightly towards the rear centre of the stage. The Child's chair is placed behind it.
- **Shelves:** Two shelves are positioned towards the rear, one on either side of the Central Table.
- **Notice Board:** Positioned towards the front-left of the stage. It may display material such as *"This Week's Releases."*
- **Librarian's Table:** Positioned towards the front-right of the stage, with the Librarian's chair.

The open areas between these fixed elements provide the principal performance space for the symbolic and historical scenes.

The Central Table remains an important visual anchor throughout the play. It is associated with the Child at the beginning and end of the play and is also incorporated into the Nalanda Scene.

3. Costumes

Child

- Bright, contemporary casual dress.

The Child should visually stand apart from the Keepers.

Librarian

- Saree (Female)
- Formal shirt and pants (Male)

Stranger

- Completely black costume.
- Black top.
- Black trousers.
- No distinguishing accessory.

The Stranger's completely black appearance visually connects him to the Keepers while distinguishing him from them through the absence of any symbolic object or identifying colour.

History

- Black top.
- Black trousers.
- **Red turban.**
- Scroll.

Science

- Black top.
- Black trousers.
- **White lab coat.**
- Test tube.

Art

- Black top.
- Black trousers.
- **Brown apron**, preferably with visible paint stains.

- Paintbrush.

Literature

- Black top.
- Black trousers.
- **Dark blue coat.**
- Book.
- Quill pen.

Philosophy

- Black top.
- Black trousers.
- **Green shawl**, draped around the body.
- Cane.

Master

- **Orange robe** covering the entire body.
- Sieve.

Disciple

- Kurta of a distinct colour.
- Black trousers.

Nalanda Students

- Kurtas of different colours.
- Black trousers.

The variation in colour helps distinguish the students as individuals from different regions and cultural backgrounds.

4. Props

Library

- Books.
- Central Table.
- Librarian's Table.
- Notice Board.
- Two shelves.
- Stack of books brought by the Librarian.

Keepers

History: Scroll and turban.
Science: Test tube and lab coat.

Art: Paintbrush and apron.
Philosophy: Cane and shawl.
Literature: Book, quill and coat.

Master and Disciple

- Sieve.

Nalanda

- Books, including the stack originally placed on the Librarian's Table.

The movement of the stack of books during the Nalanda Scene is intentional and forms part of the visual continuity of the play.

5. Opening and First Keeper Sequence

The Child begins seated at the **Central Table**, asleep with her head resting upon the single book already placed on the table.

The **Librarian enters from the audience's left**, carrying a stack of books. She places the stack on the Central Table and then proceeds to the Librarian's Table on the audience's right, where a book is already placed. She sits and begins reading.

The **Stranger enters from the audience's right**. Following the conversation between the Child and the Stranger, the Stranger begins to leave through the audience's right. Before he can fully exit, **History enters from the audience's left**.

The Child and Stranger then move towards the centre, with the Child moving ahead of the Stranger. **Science enters from the audience's right**, helping to re-establish the Child at the centre.

At this point:

- History is positioned towards the audience's left.
- The Child occupies the centre.
- The Stranger stands between the Child and Science.
- Science is positioned towards the audience's far right.

Art and Literature enter from the audience's left. Philosophy also enters from the audience's left. The five Keepers and the Stranger arrange themselves in a **semi-circle around the Child**, with sufficient spacing to ensure that each character remains visible and does not obstruct another.

6. The Sieve Story

During the narration, the Master and Disciple enact the story in the centre of the stage. The principal characters move towards the sides, leaving the central area open. **Literature** occupies a position towards the audience's left and narrates the story. The **Child and Stranger** remain towards the audience's right and observe the

action. The **Master enters from the audience's left**, while the **Disciple enters from the audience's right**. The Master and Disciple enact the story in the central space.

When Literature says:

"Again, and again, and again..."

the Disciple repeats the following action for each repetition:

1. The Disciple moves towards the **audience's right**, carrying the sieve.
2. He scoops water into the sieve.
3. He begins returning towards the Master.
4. Approximately halfway back, he looks down at the sieve and realizes that the water has disappeared.
5. He then returns towards the water and repeats the action.

The repetition should be clear to the audience while remaining natural and unhurried. At the conclusion of the story, the Master exits through the **audience's left** and the Disciple exits through the **audience's right**. The Keepers and Stranger then return to their established positions.

7. The Nalanda Scene

The staging arrangement used for the Sieve Story is repeated. The principal characters move towards the sides, leaving the central area open. **History occupies the narrating position previously occupied by Literature.**

Three students, referred to as **Student 1, Student 2 and Student 3**, enter during the scene. Student 1 enters from the audience's left and Student 2 enters from the audience's right. Student 1 moves to the Central Table and sits on it. Student 2 remains positioned to the audience's right of the Central Table.

When History says:

"Students travelled across kingdoms... simply to learn."

Student 3 enters and upon seeing Student 3, **Student 2 crosses in front of the Central Table towards the audience's left to greet Student 3**. Student 2 and Student 3 are now positioned **together to the audience's left of the Central Table**, while Student 1 remains seated on the Central Table. Student 2 and Student 3 greet one another using visibly different forms of greeting, suggesting their different cultural backgrounds. One may use a **Namaste**, while the other performs a **Japanese-style bow**. The exchange should remain brief and natural.

When History says:

"Fire!"

Student 2 and Student 3 react immediately. They **fall towards the audience's right**, looking fearfully towards the audience's left as though seeing the approaching fire.

They then **scurry away towards the audience's right**, giving the impression that they are fleeing the fire. Meanwhile, **Student 1 attempts to protect the books**. She brings the stack of books close to herself and **hugs them protectively**. As the scene concludes, Student 1 exits through the **audience's left**, carrying the stack of books. She leaves **one book behind on the Central Table**. This is the same book that was already present at the beginning of the play and on which the Child was sleeping. The principal characters then return to their established positions.

8. Final Sequence

During the Child's final recitation, the Keepers leave in the following order:

- **History exits through the audience's left.**
- **Science exits through the audience's right.**
- **Art exits through the audience's left.**
- **Philosophy exits through the audience's right.**
- **Literature exits through the audience's left.**
- **Stranger exits through the audience's right.**

The Child is left alone at the Central Table. The Child's return to sleep should be **sudden and abrupt**. She should appear fully engaged with the book one moment and then, in an almost instantaneous movement, drop forward onto the table, her head coming to rest on the open book exactly as in the opening scene. The movement should resemble a sudden jolt rather than a gradual decision to sleep.

The **Librarian enters from the audience's left**, carrying the stack of books. After the Librarian's conversation with the Child, she exits **through the audience's right.** The five Keepers and the Stranger then silently appear behind the Child. The **Stranger enters from the audience's right**, approaches from behind the Child and speaks to her in a low voice. After delivering his line, the Stranger exits **through the audience's left**.

The Child grips the back of her chair and begins to rise. After a brief pause, she looks at the book, then chooses to remain seated and opens it. The Child remains alone at the centre of the stage, reading.

9. Performance Style

The play depends upon a contrast between two worlds. The **library** should feel ordinary, quiet and grounded. The appearances of the Keepers and the historical scenes should feel imaginative without becoming excessively theatrical or cartoonish. The Keepers should be played as living embodiments of their disciplines rather than exaggerated stereotypes. The historical scenes should be physically clear enough for an audience unfamiliar with the script to understand what is occurring.

Pauses are important, particularly before significant revelations or changes in the Child's understanding. However, pauses should remain purposeful and should not unnecessarily slow the overall pace of the performance.